



Decode Your Dog



What They're Actually Trying to Tell You

A guide from your friend Coco

Because every dog is talking.
Most of us just don't know how to listen yet.

A Note to Dog Parents

Hey there.

You love your dog. Like, really love your dog.

But let's be honest. Sometimes you have no idea what she's trying to tell you. The head tilt when you talk. The grass eating at the park. That guilty look when you find a shredded pillow.



Coco big open-mouth smile, tongue out sideways, one paw waving

Sound familiar? You are not alone.

Tens of thousands of dog owners Google these exact questions every month. Why does my dog lick me? Why does my dog eat grass? The answers are usually buried in clinical jargon or clickbait that does not actually help.

Here is what nobody tells you: your dog is communicating with you all day long. Every ear position, every tail wag, every weird behaviour means something specific.

Once you learn to read those signals, everything changes.

Fewer misunderstandings. Fewer panicked vet calls that turn out to be nothing. More trust. A deeper bond than good dog and bad dog.

I built this after bringing Coco home, a fawn French Bulldog with more personality than most humans I know. I spent months learning what her faces meant and why she did all the gloriously weird stuff Frenchies do.

BY THE END OF THIS GUIDE YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

Read your dog's body language like a conversation. Understand why they do the weird stuff. Spot stress before it turns into a problem.

THINK ABOUT IT

Before you turn the page: what is one thing your dog does regularly that you have never fully understood?

The thing I have always wondered about:

How Well Do You Read Your Dog?

No judgment. Just a starting point. Tick every box that is true for you today.



Coco alert, ears straight up, head tilted, question mark doodle above

- ☐ I can tell when my dog is relaxed versus just being still.
- ☐ I know the difference between a happy wag and a nervous one.
- ☐ I recognise when my dog is asking for space.
- ☐ I understand why my dog eats grass, and whether to worry.
- ☐ I read my dog's face as a whole: ears, eyes and mouth together.
- ☐ I know what whale eye is and what it means.
- ☐ I can tell stress from play at the dog park.
- ☐ I know when a behaviour change might mean a vet visit.

YOUR SCORE

0-2

Starting fresh

Perfect. This guide was made for you. No shame, most owners are right here.

3-5

Good instincts

You have picked up signals naturally. This will sharpen what you already feel.

6-8

Already tuned in

You will love the subtle material in Sections 3 and 4 that most owners never learn.

CHALLENGE

Retake this quiz after you finish the guide. Most people jump three or four points.

1 Face & Body Basics

Your dog is talking right now. Here is how to listen.



ILLUSTRATION

Coco alert mode, orange sweater, ears forward, sight-line to a tiny squirrel

This is alert mode.

See the ears? Forward and perked. Eyes focused. Mouth closed. She spotted something. Maybe a squirrel, maybe you reaching for the treat bag.

The trick is reading the full picture, not one signal on its own.

Ears up means I am listening!

THE FACE — read it like a sentence, not a single word

● EARS FORWARD

Alert, interested, focused
Something caught their attention

● EARS BACK / FLAT

Anxious, scared, appeasing
They need reassurance, not correction

● SOFT RELAXED EYES

Content, comfortable, trusting
A happy dog. Enjoy the moment

● HARD STARE

Tension, fixation, high arousal
Do not approach. Watch carefully

● WHALE EYE

Whites of the eyes showing
Step back. Do not push the interaction

● RELAXED OPEN MOUTH

Happy, at ease, comfortable
The dog version of a real smile

Look at your dog right now. What are their ears and eyes doing?

MINI GAME

Signal Match

Draw a line from each face to what it actually means. Answer key is on page 12.

THE FACE



THE MEANING

Happy and comfortable

Alert, something caught them

Anxious, needs reassurance

Stressed, do not approach

THE BODY — tail, posture and weight

The tail gets all the attention, but posture tells the real story.

TAIL HIGH & STIFF

Aroused or asserting. Approach slowly.

TAIL MID, LOOSE WAG

Relaxed and happy. This is the good wag.

TAIL LOW OR TUCKED

Fearful. Give space now.

WEIGHT FORWARD

Confident, interested, about to engage.

WEIGHT BACK

Nervous, uncertain, wants distance.

BELLY UP

Full trust or forced submission. Context matters.

DID YOU KNOW

A wagging tail does not always mean a happy dog. A stiff, high, fast wag often signals arousal or tension, not joy. Read the whole body.

THE TWO POSES OWNERS CONFUSE MOST

THE PLAY BOW

Front legs flat, bottom in the air, tail wagging.
Loose, bouncy energy with a goofy grin.



ILLUSTRATION

Coco in a play bow, motion lines

THE FREEZE

Completely still. Stiff body. Eyes locked. This is not calm. This is a dog deciding what to do next.



ILLUSTRATION

Coco frozen stiff, wide eyes

THE GOLDEN RULE

Playing dogs take voluntary breaks. Stressed dogs do not pause. If your dog freezes mid interaction, step in.

2

The Weird Stuff, Explained

The things you Google at 2am. Finally answered.



ILLUSTRATION

Coco outdoors chewing a blade of grass in a grass patch with three daisies

THE GRASS EATER

Verdict: perfectly normal

Your dog is not sick. Wild wolves had plant material in up to 74 percent of scat samples. A study of 12 dogs found the hungrier they were, the more grass they ate. Most dogs do not vomit afterwards.

Worry only if they eat obsessively, vomit repeatedly, or the grass is treated.

THE HEAD TILTER

Verdict: tuning you in

The tilt is not confusion. Your dog is adjusting their ears to locate sound and moving their head to see past their own muzzle. Long muzzled dogs tilt more. Flat faced dogs like Coco stare instead.

Next time they tilt, keep talking. They are actively listening.

THE ZOOMIE RUNNER

Verdict: pure joy

FRAPs, or Frenetic Random Activity Periods, are normal energy releases. Your dog is not broken. Most common after baths, naps, meals, or the moment you pick up the leash.

Do not try to stop zoomies. Clear the space and enjoy the show.

MYTH OR FACT

Tick your answer

Three things people say about dogs. Only one of them is true.

Dogs eat grass to make themselves vomit.

TRUE

FALSE

A wagging tail always means a happy dog.

TRUE

FALSE

The head tilt means your dog is listening harder.

TRUE

FALSE

Answer key on page 12.

Three More You Have Probably Wondered About



Close up of Coco's face, tongue out, joyful squinty eyes, sticker style

THE GUILTY LOOKER

Verdict: not actually guilt

That guilty look, ears back and eyes averted, is not guilt. Dogs do not connect past actions to your current reaction. What you are seeing is appeasement. They read your upset body language and try to calm you down.

They are saying: you seem upset, I am trying to fix it. Not: I regret the shoe.

THE LICKER

Verdict: it depends on context

Licking is the single most Googled dog question. A few licks on your hand is affection or salt. Obsessive licking of one body part can be pain or anxiety. Licking the air can be nausea.

Watch for constant paw licking, lip licking without food, or one repeated spot.

THE DIGGER

Verdict: ancient instinct

Burying food is not greed. It is survival wiring. Hiding food meant surviving lean times, and your spoiled house dog still runs that program. Digging is also temperature control and boredom.

For indoor digging, more mental stimulation usually helps. Puzzle feeders and sniff games.

NEXT TIME YOUR DOG DOES SOMETHING WEIRD, PAUSE AND ASK WHAT THEY ARE TELLING YOU

My dog's weirdest habit:

What I think it means now:

WORD SCRAMBLE

Unjumble the behaviour

INCGKLI the most Googled dog question

— — — — —

INGGGDI ancient survival wiring

— — — — —

3

Calming Signals

The quiet warnings most owners miss.

Norwegian trainer Turid Rugaas documented these across thousands of dogs. They are consistent across every breed: your dog's polite way of saying I need space, or let us not fight. Once you learn them you will see them everywhere.



YAWNING

Not tired. Stress, or calming a tense moment.

At the vet, in the car, around strangers.



LIP LICKING

A quick tongue flick means anxiety.

Nail trims, handling, unfamiliar places.



TURNING AWAY

Deliberate avoidance. That is too much.

When kids hug or strangers lean over.



ILLUSTRATION

Coco puppy face, extra large soft eyes,
mid slow blink, calm swirls



GROUND SNIFFING

Suddenly fascinated by the floor. Deflecting.

They are saying: I am uncomfortable, give me space.



SLOW BLINKING

Trust and relaxation signal.

The dog equivalent of a soft smile. You can do it back.

THE R.E.A.D. METHOD

Your framework for reading any dog, anywhere.

R — Relax yourself first. Dogs read your stress before you read theirs.

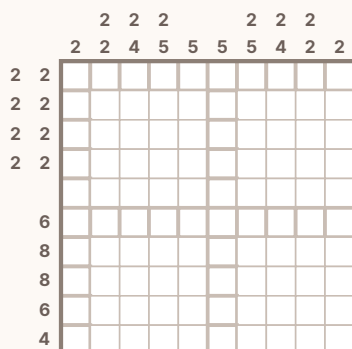
E — Eyes, ears, mouth. Scan the face for the overall expression.

A — Assess the body. Tail, posture, weight distribution.

D — Decide. Comfortable, or do I need to give space?

PICTURE CROSS

Shade the squares



HOW TO PLAY

Numbers tell you how many squares to shade in that row or column, in that order. A gap of at least one empty square sits between each group.

Work out which squares must be shaded. Fill them all in and a picture appears.

Fill it in correctly and Coco's paw print appears.

4 Stress vs. Play

Use this at the dog park tomorrow. Seriously.

You are at the dog park. Two dogs are wrestling. Is it fun, or about to go wrong? This chart tells you in three seconds.

STRESS	PLAY
● Stiff, tense body	● Loose, wiggly body
● High rigid or tucked tail	● Mid level wide wag
● Closed mouth, lip curl	● Open mouth, relaxed jaw
● Hard stare, whale eye	● Soft, squinty eyes
● Freezing, cowering	● Bouncy, exaggerated moves
● Low sustained growl	● Short, high play growl
● No voluntary pauses	● Takes breaks, re-engages

THE THREE SECOND TEST

Watch for pauses. Playing dogs stop voluntarily, check in, then go again. Stressed dogs do not pause. If one dog freezes or tries to leave and the other keeps pushing, step in calmly and separate them.

TRIAGE DRILL

Play or stress?

Read each one and circle your answer. Then check against the chart above.

1	Both dogs loose and bouncy, pausing every few seconds to check in	PLAY	STRESS
2	One dog stiff and still, the other pushing into its space	PLAY	STRESS
3	Wide open mouths, exaggerated leaps, taking turns chasing	PLAY	STRESS

Answer key on page 12.

A

ILLUSTRATION

Two dogs playing happily - version A

B

ILLUSTRATION

Same scene - version B with 6 changes

Circle the 6 differences between picture A and picture B.



5 When It's Not Behaviour

Sometimes what looks like a mood is a health signal.

This is the section I hope you never need, but the one that could matter most. A sudden behavioural change can mean something physical is going on underneath.



ILLUSTRATION

Coco lying down, chin on paws, gentle worried eyes, stethoscope doodle

CONSIDER CALLING YOUR VET IF YOU NOTICE

Sudden aggression or snapping

Could signal pain. Dogs in pain lash out at touch they normally accept.

Hiding or withdrawing

A social dog going quiet may be ill, injured or in discomfort.

Obsessive licking of one spot

Localised pain, a skin issue, or anxiety. Not just a quirky habit.

House training regression

Urinary infection, digestive trouble, or cognitive decline in older dogs.

Loss of interest in food or play

Could be minor, could be serious. Always worth checking.

Panting without exercise

Pain, anxiety, respiratory issues or overheating.

WANT THE FULL HEALTH AND EMERGENCY GUIDE

This guide covers behaviour. For emergency costs, the call-vet-now triage table and the five preventable emergencies, read our other free guide: The \$1,000 Vet Bill.

DO THIS TODAY — fill these in before you ever need them

My vet:

Nearest 24 hour emergency vet:

Coco's 7-Day Body Language Challenge

One small observation a day. By Day 7 you will read your dog like a pro.



ILLUSTRATION

Coco mid zoomie, ears flapping back,
tongue out, speed lines

1

OBSERVE

Watch your dog for five minutes without interacting.

What did you notice? _____

5 min

☐

2

THE FACE

Focus only on ears, eyes and mouth. Track three changes.

What face did they make? _____

5 min

☐

3

THE TAIL

Watch the tail all day. High, mid or low? Stiff or loose?

What did the tail say? _____

All day

☐

4

WEIRD STUFF

Did they do something weird? Note what and when.

What was it really? _____

All day

☐

5

CALMING

Spot one calming signal. Yawn, lip lick or ground sniff.

What triggered it? _____

10 min

☐

6

INTERACTION

Watch them meet another dog. Use the stress and play chart.

Play or stress? _____

15 min

☐

7

FULL READ

Read the whole dog. Face plus body plus context.

What is your dog saying? _____

10 min

☐

BONUS CHALLENGE

Take a photo of your dog each day. By Day 7 you will have a visual diary of every signal you learned to read.

Quick-Reference Cheat Sheet

Print it. Screenshot it. Stick it on the fridge.

THE FACE

Forward ears = alert
Flat ears = anxious
Soft eyes = happy
Hard stare = tension
Whale eye = stressed
Open mouth = content

THE BODY

High stiff tail = aroused
Loose wag = relaxed
Tucked tail = fear
Weight forward = confident
Play bow = let's play
Freeze = step in now

WEIRD STUFF

Grass = instinct
Head tilt = listening
Zoomies = pure joy
Guilty look = appeasement
Digging = survival wiring
Licking = context matters

R.E.A.D. METHOD

Relax > Eyes, ears, mouth > Assess the body > Decide: comfortable or needs space

CALMING SIGNALS

Yawning · Lip licking · Turning away · Ground sniffing · Slow blinking

STRESS vs PLAY

Playing dogs pause. Stressed dogs do not. Freeze means step in now.

VET CHECK

A sudden behaviour change can mean a health issue. When in doubt, call your vet.

ANSWER KEY

No peeking until you have had a go

PAGE 4 — SIGNAL MATCH

Ears flat back = anxious, needs reassurance
Whale eye = stressed, do not approach
Relaxed open mouth = happy and comfortable
Ears forward = alert, something caught them

PAGE 6 — MYTH OR FACT

1. False. Most dogs do not vomit after grass.
2. False. A stiff fast wag can mean arousal.
3. True. The tilt helps them hear and see you.

PAGE 9 — TRIAGE DRILL

1. Play. Voluntary pauses are the tell.
2. Stress. One dog frozen, one pushing.
3. Play. Loose, exaggerated, taking turns.

You Did It. Now What?

You just learned to read your dog's body language, decode their weirdest behaviours, and spot stress before it becomes a problem. That puts you ahead of most dog owners on the planet.

THE COCO LIBRARY — the complete guide pack

Six guides covering dental health, flat-face care, apartment living, nutrition myths, puppy foundations and senior mobility. Everything Coco's human learned, in one pack.

Available on the thank-you page after your download.